witnesses, the interrogation often revolved around the shipping company. It transpired that some of the secret meetings had taken place in Ottapidaram, VOC's home village. The second-class magistrate of Senkottai, based on his investigations, stated, 'Of course, connection with … Ottapidaram, the birthplace of Chidambaram Pillai, is seen and the plot must evidently have been hatched at Ottapidaram. It is stated that Chidambaram Pillai's clerk used now and then to visit the house of Arunachalam Pillai [an accused]. This boy used to collect subscriptions for the National fund of G. Subramania Iyer and was secretary of an obscure association there.' Vanchi had also visited Ottapidaram on at least one occasion.

One of the exhibits (Exhibit GGGG) in the trial was a cartoon from Bharati's *India* of 13-2-1909 (see figure above, on p. 358). It is a cartoon depicting a ship loaded with wheat to England, and the comment, 'all the industries of the country are ruined by Englishmen, the shipping trade of the various places (mentioned) were also ruined and if "a black man" starts a ship trade, he is sentenced to 6 years RI [rigorous imprisonment], as the great man Chidambaram Pillai'.

The verdict, delivered on 15 February 1912, dwelt at some length on SSNCo. Tracing the events leading up to the Tirunelveli 'Riots', the judges acknowledged that VOC was 'mainly instrumental in starting the *Swadeshi* Steam Navigation Company' and added that 'the company attracted to itself a good deal of the traffic between Tuticorin and Colombo till then in the hands of the British Indian Steam Navigation Company. He [VOC] thus became, perhaps naturally, a violent opponent of the British Indian Steam Navigation Company and certain other English companies in Tuticorin. He delivered a series of lectures in which he advised mainly a boycott of English goods, English courts and in fact everything appertaining to the governing race'.

Quoting extensively from the high court judgment in VOC's appeal against his double life imprisonment, the judgement summarized his message in the following terms: